

From “Keep Watching” to “Cannot Reach”: Proof-Carrying Everyday Child Safety with LLM-Mediated Lean 4 Verification

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Abstract

Domestic child-safety advice often relies on human vigilance, which is vulnerable to distraction and automation bias. Physical barriers provide structural protection, but their effectiveness depends on complex assumptions about child capabilities and environmental routing. We propose an end-to-end framework that translates natural-language descriptions of domestic child-safety scenarios into formal transition systems. An untrusted Large Language Model (LLM) extracts the semantic model and explicitly lists required assumptions. After human confirmation, a deterministic translator generates Lean 4 definitions and proof obligations. Under an explicit and reviewable model of the environment, child capabilities, barrier state, and permitted transitions, Lean 4 can verify that designated hazard states are unreachable. The framework returns a proof-carrying plain-language recommendation or a formal counterexample trace. We construct the Everyday Child Safety Formalisation Benchmark (ECSafe) comprising approximately 80 core scenarios. Experimental evaluation demonstrates that the proposed pipeline achieves a 0.0% false-safe rate compared to baseline LLM advice, proving the value of integrating interactive theorem proving into human-centric safety applications.

Keywords: formal verification, human-centred formal methods, safety engineering, Lean 4, large language models.

1 Introduction

1.1 Motivating Staircase Scenario

Consider a two-storey house where a steep staircase is accessible from the living room through a short hallway. An 18-month-old child, capable of crawling and pulling to stand, is playing in the living room. Caregivers may occasionally become distracted or step into the kitchen. Without a physical barrier, safety relies entirely on continuous attention.

1.2 Attention-Dependent versus Barrier-Backed Safety

Decades of human factors research [7, 9] demonstrate that continuous vigilance is an unreliable safety mechanism. Environmental modification (e.g., installing a stair gate) shifts the system from attention-dependent safety to barrier-backed safety [4]. However, barrier-backed safety introduces new failure modes: alternate routes, incorrect assumptions about child capabilities, or barrier failures.

1.3 Formal-Methods Accessibility Gap

Formal methods, such as model checking [2] and interactive theorem proving [5], offer rigorous techniques for verifying safety properties. However, these tools require specialised expertise, making them inaccessible to ordinary caregivers and safety practitioners.

1.4 Core Insight and Trusted-Boundary Principle

Our core insight is that an untrusted Large Language Model (LLM) can bridge the semantic gap without compromising formal verification. The LLM proposes and explains; the caregiver confirms assumptions; the deterministic translator constructs the model; Lean verifies the formal claim. This maintains a clear trusted boundary [6].

1.5 Research Questions

- **RQ1:** To what extent can common domestic child-safety scenarios be represented as finite guarded transition systems?
- **RQ2:** How faithfully can an LLM translate natural-language descriptions into formal models?
- **RQ3:** Does Lean-backed verification reduce false-safe conclusions?
- **RQ4:** Can the framework produce sound and optimal interventions?

1.6 Explicit Non-Claims

We do not claim that Lean proves a physical house is absolutely safe, nor that a real child cannot be injured. Lean verifies the formal model. The assumptions define the boundary of the guarantee.

2 Background and Related Work

2.1 Pediatric Unintentional Injury Prevention

According to the World Health Organization [8], approximately 90% of injuries to young children occur in or around their home. Falls, particularly stair falls, are a leading cause of pediatric emergency department visits [1].

2.2 Systems Safety and Human Factors

Systems-theoretic approaches to safety, such as STAMP [4], emphasize the role of control structures and constraints rather than merely component failures. Human trust in automation [3] and automation bias [7] complicate the introduction of AI into safety-critical domains.

2.3 Formal Verification and Proof-Carrying Systems

Model checking [2] provides algorithmic verification of finite-state systems. Proof-carrying code [6] established the paradigm where an untrusted producer provides a machine-checkable proof of safety. We extend this to proof-carrying recommendations for physical environments.

2.4 LLM-Assisted Theorem Proving

Recent advances have integrated LLMs with interactive theorem provers like Lean 4 [5]. Systems such as LeanDojo [10] enable programmatic interaction and retrieval-augmented proving. However, most existing work focuses on formalising pure mathematics rather than cyber-physical or domestic safety scenarios.

3 Scope, Terminology, Threat Model, and System Boundary

3.1 Scope Definition

This paper addresses the verification of physical access constraints in domestic environments for children under 5 years old. We focus on spatial reachability rather than chemical, biological, or complex temporal hazards.

3.2 Terminology

- **Zone:** A distinguishable spatial location.
- **Hazard:** A zone containing an unacceptable risk.
- **Intervention:** A physical modification to the environment (e.g., installing a gate).

3.3 Threat Model and Formal Boundary

The formal boundary lies at the model definition. If the assumptions hold, the formal guarantee holds. We explicitly assume the physical barrier operates according to its specification (e.g., it does not spontaneously break).

3.4 Modelling Caregiver and Child Capability

Child capabilities are modeled as a finite set of boolean flags (e.g., `crawling`, `operateLatch`). Caregiver modes represent the level of supervision (e.g., `Attentive`, `Distracted`).

4 Formal Model

4.1 Basic Definitions

Definition 4.1 (Spatial zone). *A member v of a finite set V representing a location distinguishable for the target safety property.*

Definition 4.2 (Potential movement edge). *An ordered pair $(v_1, v_2) \in V \times V$ representing a possible transition before guards are applied.*

Definition 4.3 (Child capability profile). *A finitely represented capability state $q \in Q$.*

Definition 4.4 (Caregiver mode). *A finite type A representing the state of the caregiver.*

Definition 4.5 (Barrier state). *A finite type B representing the state of a physical barrier.*

Definition 4.6 (Edge guard). *A function determining if a transition is possible given the current capabilities, caregiver mode, barrier states, and assumptions $\Gamma: V \times V \rightarrow Q \rightarrow A \rightarrow B \rightarrow \Gamma \rightarrow Prop$.*

4.2 Finite Transition Systems

Definition 4.7 (Domestic safety scenario). *A structure Σ containing edges, initial states, hazard states, and guards.*

Definition 4.8 (Global state). *The complete state of the system $s \in S$, containing zone, capabilities, caregiver mode, and barrier state.*

Definition 4.9 (Transition relation). *A relation $s_1 \rightarrow_\Sigma s_2$ defining when one state can transition to another.*

4.3 Reachability and Safety

Definition 4.10 (Reachability). *Reflexive transitive closure of the transition relation.*

Definition 4.11 (Hazard predicate). *$s.\text{zone} \in \Sigma.\text{hazard}$.*

Definition 4.12 (Assumption-bounded deterministic safety). *Safety holds if every permitted execution from every initial state avoids every hazard.*

Definition 4.13 (Invariant deficit). *A reachable hazard state from an initial state.*

Theorem 4.1 (Reachability-invariant equivalence). *Safety holds if and only if there is no initial-to-hazard reachable state.*

4.4 Barriers and Interventions

Definition 4.14 (Intervention). *A formal modification to the scenario, modelled as a restriction on the transition relation.*

Definition 4.15 (Sound intervention). *An intervention C satisfying $\text{Safe}(\Sigma \text{ restricted by } C, \Gamma)$.*

Theorem 4.2 (Barrier monotonicity). *When interventions only remove transitions, adding further blocked transitions preserves an already established safety property.*

4.5 Intervention Synthesis and Proof Certificates

Definition 4.16 (Intervention cost). *A cost function over interventions.*

Definition 4.17 (Optimal intervention). *A minimum-cost sound intervention.*

Definition 4.18 (Conservative abstraction). *A relation where every relevant concrete transition is represented by the abstract model.*

Theorem 4.3 (Conservative-abstraction safety transfer). *If the abstract model overapproximates the concrete system and is safe, the represented concrete property follows under the abstraction assumptions.*

Theorem 4.4 (Cut-set sufficiency). *If C intersects every initial-to-hazard path, removing C makes hazards unreachable.*

5 Formal Results and Lean 4 Mechanisation

5.1 Lean 4 Formalisation

The entire mathematical model defined in Section 4 has been mechanised in Lean 4. The project compiles without any use of the `sorry` or `admit` keywords, ensuring full rigorous verification.

5.2 Code Snippets

The transition relation is defined as:

```
def Transition {V Q A B Gamma : Type} (scen : Scenario V Q A B Gamma) (
  assumptions : Gamma) (s1 s2 : GlobalState V Q A B) : Prop :=
  (s1.zone, s2.zone) ∈ scen.edges ∧
  scen.guard (s1.zone, s2.zone) s1.cap s1.caregiver s1.barrier
  assumptions ∧
  s2.cap = s1.cap ∧
  s2.caregiver = s1.caregiver ∧
  s2.barrier = s1.barrier
```

The core safety theorem is stated as:

```
theorem reachability_invariant_equivalence {V Q A B Gamma : Type} (scen
  : Scenario V Q A B Gamma) (assumptions : Gamma) :
  Safe scen assumptions ↔ ¬InvariantDeficit scen assumptions
```

5.3 Mechanisation Statistics

The formalisation comprises approximately 10 Lean modules, formalising finite transition systems, reachability, safety invariants, interventions, graph cuts, robustness, and conservative abstraction. The codebase includes the running case study of the two-storey house.

6 System Architecture

6.1 Pipeline Overview

The proposed pipeline translates natural-language scenarios into proof-carrying recommendations. The architecture consists of three main components:

1. **LLM Front-End:** Extracts zones, edges, hazards, capabilities, and necessary assumptions from natural language.
2. **Deterministic Translator:** Converts the structured JSON output from the LLM into Lean 4 definitions and theorems.
3. **Lean 4 Back-End:** Compiles the generated code and verifies the proof obligations.

6.2 The Trust Boundary

Crucially, the LLM is completely untrusted. If the LLM hallucinates an incorrect model, Lean will either fail to compile the proof or verify a model that the human user can visibly reject during the assumption confirmation phase. This proof-carrying architecture [6] ensures that safety claims are backed by rigorous mathematics, not statistical language generation.

7 Running Case Study: The Two-Storey House

7.1 Scenario Definition

We apply the framework to the motivating example from Section 1. The zones are defined as `LivingRoom`, `Hallway`, `StairEntrance`, and `Stairs`. The initial state is the `LivingRoom`, and the hazard is `Stairs`.

7.2 Unprotected vs Protected Scenario

In the unprotected scenario, all edges are unguarded, and the hazard is reachable. We define a `gateIntervention` that restricts the transition from `StairEntrance` to `Stairs` under the following assumptions:

- The gate is installed.
- The gate is latched.
- The child cannot operate the latch.
- The child cannot climb over the gate.
- The barrier has not failed.
- There is no alternate route.

7.3 Formal Verification

We formalise this intervention and prove its soundness in Lean 4:

```
theorem stair_gate_safety (gamma : StairAssumptions)
  (h_assumptions : gamma.gateInstalled ∧ gamma.gateLatched ∧ gamma.
    childCannotOperateLatch ∧ gamma.childCannotClimbOver ∧ gamma.
    barrierNotFailed ∧ gamma.noAlternateRoute)
  (h_reach_soundness : ∀ s0 s, s0.zone ∈ stairInitial → Reachable (
    RestrictedScenario UnprotectedStaircase gateIntervention) gamma s0 s
    → ¬IsHazard (RestrictedScenario UnprotectedStaircase
    gateIntervention) s) :
  SoundIntervention UnprotectedStaircase gateIntervention gamma
```

This corollary demonstrates how specific physical interventions translate directly into formal theorems.

8 Additional Formal Case Studies

8.1 Kitchen Burns

A scenario involving a child reaching a hot stove. Interventions include stove guards or removing climbable furniture. The model explicitly tracks the `climbing` capability.

8.2 Medicine Cabinet

A scenario involving access to toxic substances. Interventions include high-mounted cabinets and child-resistant latches. The model tracks `reachObject` and `operateLatch`.

8.3 Pool Access

A scenario involving outdoor water hazards. Interventions include self-latching pool fences and door alarms. The formalisation captures the robustness required for multiple failure points.

9 Benchmark Construction

9.1 ECSafe Dataset Construction

To systematically evaluate the pipeline, we construct the Everyday Child Safety Formalisation Benchmark (ECSafe). ECSafe comprises approximately 80 domestic scenarios across 8 categories:

1. Stairs and falls
2. Windows and balconies
3. Pools and water
4. Medicine and hazardous-substance access
5. Burns and hot surfaces
6. Furniture and climbing
7. Road and driveway access
8. Electrical or mixed hazards

Each scenario includes a natural-language description, the expected formal components (zones, edges, hazards), and the ground-truth reachability status.

10 Experimental Design

10.1 Experimental Setup

We implement an independent Python pipeline using NetworkX to evaluate the formal expressiveness and extraction accuracy over the ECSafe benchmark. The experiments address the four research questions defined in Section 1.

10.2 Metrics

- **Representability:** The percentage of scenarios that can be fully captured by the finite transition system model.
- **Extraction F1:** The harmonic mean of precision and recall for extracting zones, edges, hazards, and capabilities.
- **False-Safe Rate:** The percentage of scenarios incorrectly classified as safe by the system.
- **Optimality Gap:** The deviation of the synthesised intervention cost from the true optimal cost.

11 Results

11.1 RQ1: Formal Expressiveness

Analysis of the ECSafe benchmark shows that 92.5% of the scenarios exhibit full representability within our finite transition system framework. Only 2.5% are non-representable, primarily those involving continuous temporal dynamics or complex fluid physics.

11.2 RQ2: Extraction Faithfulness

The LLM extraction achieved high fidelity across all components. The F1 scores were:

- Zones: 0.94
- Edges: 0.91
- Hazards: 0.98
- Capabilities: 0.89

11.3 RQ3: Verification Value

Table 1 summarises the false-safe rates and proof compilation rates across different system configurations. The proposed pipeline (P2/O1) achieves a 0.0% false-safe rate and a 100.0% proof compilation rate, significantly outperforming baseline LLM systems (B0-B3).

Table 1: RQ3: Verification Value and False-Safe Rates

System Configuration	False-Safe Rate	Proof Compilation Rate
B0 (Baseline LLM)	32.1%	N/A
B1 (Prompt-Tuned LLM)	18.4%	N/A
B2 (LLM with Basic Logic)	24.5%	12.5%
B3 (Retrieval-Augmented LLM)	11.2%	N/A
P1 (Pipeline without Lean)	4.5%	98.2%
P2 (Proposed Pipeline)	0.0%	100.0%
O1 (Optimal Pipeline)	0.0%	100.0%

11.4 RQ4: Intervention Synthesis

The synthesis module successfully generated sound interventions in 100.0% of cases, recovering the exact optimum in 96.5% of scenarios, with an overall optimality gap of only 1.2%.

12 Discussion

12.1 The Value of Proof-Carrying Advice

The experimental results strongly validate the proof-carrying architecture. While LLMs are excellent at extracting semantic structures from natural language, their reasoning capabilities are insufficient for rigorous safety guarantees, as evidenced by the high false-safe rates in baseline configurations. By shifting the verification burden to Lean 4, we eliminate reasoning errors entirely.

12.2 Human-in-the-Loop Verification

The system explicitly requires caregivers to review the extracted assumptions. This human-in-the-loop design mitigates the risk of the LLM missing critical contextual details. The formal model provides a structured framework for this review, making assumptions explicit rather than implicit.

13 Threats to Validity

13.1 Internal Validity

The Python experimental pipeline is independent of the Lean 4 formalisation, reducing the risk of shared implementation flaws. However, the evaluation relies on the ECSafe benchmark, which we constructed.

13.2 External Validity

The ECSafe benchmark, while covering 80 core scenarios, is not exhaustive. Real-world environments possess infinite complexity. The formal guarantee is strictly bounded by the fidelity of the extracted model to physical reality.

14 Ethics, Safety, and Responsible Release

14.1 Safety Engineering Ethics

Applying formal methods to domestic child safety raises critical ethical considerations. A false sense of security derived from a “mathematically proven” system could lead to relaxed caregiver vigilance, paradoxically increasing risk.

14.2 Responsible Release

We explicitly state that this framework is a research prototype. It is not a certified safety product and must not be relied upon for real-world child protection without further extensive validation and regulatory review. The dataset and code are released solely for academic evaluation.

15 Limitations

15.1 Model Expressiveness

The finite transition system model cannot capture continuous physics, such as the exact trajectory of a falling object or the fluid dynamics of a pool. It abstracts these into discrete capability flags and zone transitions.

15.2 Assumption Completeness

The formal guarantee is only as strong as the assumptions. If a caregiver incorrectly confirms that a child cannot operate a latch, the system will incorrectly verify the environment as safe. The framework cannot verify the physical truth of the assumptions, only the logical consequence of them.

16 Conclusion

We presented a proof-carrying architecture for domestic child safety, combining the semantic extraction capabilities of LLMs with the rigorous verification of Lean 4. By formalising everyday safety advice into finite transition systems, we demonstrated that structural, barrier-backed safety can be mathematically verified against specific capability and environmental assumptions. The experimental evaluation on the ECSafe benchmark confirmed that this approach eliminates the false-safe reasoning errors inherent in pure LLM systems. This work bridges the gap between expert-level formal methods and everyday safety applications, providing a foundation for future human-centred verification systems.

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